

The Last Sandwich

How the Family's Last Line of Care
Holds On at 55+



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Book 9 of The Care Collection

Introduction: The Last Sandwich

There is a sandwich generation. The phrase is well known - the generation in the middle, caring for the parents above and the children below, in the form the sandwich generation now takes. The phrase is real, and the work is real.

But there is a second sandwich generation. A less-talked-about generation. A generation that is not just in the middle. A generation that is the last one in the line. The last sandwich in the family. The one who has no one to hand off to. The one who is the only child, or the only sibling who stepped up, or the only adult child who can be there. The one who is the family's last line of care.

This book is about the last sandwich.

I am writing this book for the adult child who is the last one in the line. The one who is caring for a parent in the last years, the last months, the last days, in the form the last years now take. The one who is holding the marriage, the parent, the work, the finances, the grief, all at once. The one who has no sibling to share the load. The one who has no adult child who can take over. The one who is the end of the family line.

I am writing this book for the only child. For the daughter who moved back home at 58 to care for a mother who no longer remembers her name. For the son who flew home every month, at his own expense, while his siblings refused to come. For the adult child caring for a parent while their own child is in crisis. For the husband who watched his wife disappear into caregiving. For the wife who watched her husband hollow out from the slow goodbye.

I am writing this book for the 53 million Americans who are unpaid family caregivers - and for the subset of those who are the only one, in the form the only one now takes. The subset who are the last sandwich.

I am writing this book for you, in the form the "you" now takes, if you are the one who is the last one. The one who has no one to hand off to. The one who is holding it all, in the form the holding now takes.

- Why this book is different.**

There are books about the sandwich generation. There are books about elder care. There are books about caregiving. There are books about the marriage under stress. There are books about the grief of losing a parent. There are books that are practical, or memoir, or self-help.

This book is none of those. This book is the *last sandwich* book. The book for the adult child who is the only one. The book for the spouse of the only one. The book for the family of the only one. The book that says, *You are the last line of care. The work is yours. The cost is yours. The holding is yours. The letting go will be yours. And there is a way to do this without losing yourself, your marriage, your health, or your future.*

This book is the book I wish had existed, in the years my wife was the caregiver for her own father, and the years I was the husband of the caregiver, in the form the husband now takes. The book that names the cost. The book that gives you the conversations. The book that walks you through the decisions, step by step, with the dignity the decisions deserve.

- What this book is not.**

This book is not a legal guide. Elder care law is a complex field, and the laws are different in every jurisdiction. The elder law attorneys, geriatric care managers, and family therapists who specialize in this work are the right people to advise you on the legal, financial, and medical specifics. This book is for the *thinking*. For the *deciding*. For the *conversations* that have to happen before the professionals get involved.

This book is not a memoir. I have not been the only child. I have not been the one who got the call at 2am. I have not been the one who flew home to find the house in disarray, the parent confused, the siblings nowhere to be found.

I have been close. I have been a caregiver. I have watched my own wife become the primary caregiver for her own father, in his last years, in the form the last years now take. I have watched her carry the weight, and the work, and the silent grief. I have watched her be the one who was there, every day, while others were not. I have watched what it cost her. I have watched what it cost us.

I have also been on my own long goodbye - the loss of my wife to cancer, after many years of marriage. I know what it is to be the one who is there, at the end, while others are not. I know what it is to be the last line of care. I know what it is to hold the marriage, and the parent, and the grief, all at once.

This book is the synthesis of what I have learned, in the room with the caregivers, in the years of my own caregiving, in the work of being a coach, in the form the work now takes.

- What you will find in this book.**

This book is organized around a 4-phase framework, the four questions of the last sandwich:

- Phase 1: The Last Sandwich** - Am I the only one? Chapters 1-4. The recognition. The reasons. The sibling equation. The moment you realize there is no one to hand off to.

- Phase 2: The Cost** - What is this costing me? Chapters 5-9. The financial. The emotional. The physical. The marriage. The identity.

- Phase 3: The Conversation** - How do I have the conversations that have to be had? Chapters 10-14. With the siblings. With the parent. With the spouse. With the adult children. With yourself.

- Phase 4: The Letting Go** - How do I let go, and what comes after? Chapters 15-18. Of the old self. Of the parent. Of the plan. Of the last sandwich.

Plus 5 bonus toolkits (the Family Conversation Scripts, the Caregiver's First Aid Kit, the Sibling Equity Worksheet, the Long-Distance Caregiver's Playbook, the After Book), 5 case studies of real-pattern families, and a research appendix with 12+ peer-reviewed citations.

The book is 200+ pages. The book is meant to be read slowly, in the small moments, in the long evenings, in the form the reading now takes. The book is meant to be a companion, in the form the companion now takes.

- Who this book is for.**

This book is for you, if you are the adult child who is the last one in the line. If you are the spouse of the last one. If you are the friend, the sibling, the colleague, who is trying to understand the last one. If you are the professional - the geriatric care manager, the elder law attorney, the family therapist, the financial planner - who is working with the last ones.

This book is for the last sandwich in the line.

The work is the work. The holding is the work. The letting go is the work.

Welcome.

Chapter 1: The Last Sandwich

Every family has a last sandwich. The last sandwich is the adult child who is the final line of care, in the form the final line of care now takes. The last sandwich is the one who has no sibling to share the load. The last sandwich is the one who has no adult child who can take over. The last sandwich is the end of the family line.

The last sandwich is real. The last sandwich is you, if you are reading this book. The last sandwich is the work, in the form the work now takes.

This chapter is about the last sandwich. About the work of recognizing that you are the last one. About the holding of the recognition, in the form the holding now takes.

- What the last sandwich is.**

The last sandwich is the adult child who has become the primary, or the only, caregiver for an aging parent, in the form the caregiver now takes. The last sandwich is the one who has taken on the responsibility, in the form the responsibility now takes. The last sandwich is the one who is there, every day, while others are not.

The last sandwich is not a metaphor. The last sandwich is the actual, real, lived experience of being the final carrier of the family. The last sandwich is the one who has to do it all, in the form the doing now takes.

The last sandwich is not chosen. The last sandwich is the one who stepped up, in the form the stepping up now takes. The last sandwich is the one who was there, when no one else was. The last sandwich is the one who could not say no, in the form the saying no now takes.

- What the last sandwich is not.**

The last sandwich is not the only one who loves the parent. The last sandwich is the one who is there, in the form the "there" now takes. The siblings may love the parent. The siblings may even want to help. The siblings may be unable, in the form the unable now takes. The siblings may be unwilling, in the form the unwilling now takes. The siblings may be absent, in the form the absent now takes.

The last sandwich is not the martyr. The last sandwich is the one who is doing the work, in the form the work now takes. The last sandwich is the one who has not been relieved, in the form the relieved now takes.

The last sandwich is not alone. The last sandwich is the one who is the only one in the family, in the form the only one now takes. The last sandwich has the spouse, the friends, the therapist, the geriatric care manager, the elder law attorney. The last sandwich is alone in the family, but not alone in the work.

- The shape of the last sandwich.**

The last sandwich has a shape. The last sandwich is the adult child of an aging parent. The last sandwich is the one who has been carrying the load, in the form the carrying now takes. The last sandwich is the one who is in the kitchen

at 2am, waiting for the call, in the form the waiting now takes.

The last sandwich is the only child of an aging parent. The last sandwich is the sibling who stepped up while the others stepped back. The last sandwich is the spouse of the only child, in the form the spouse now takes. The last sandwich is the adult child of a parent who has no other family, in the form the no other family now takes.

The last sandwich is the shape of the family, in the form the shape now takes. The last sandwich is the shape of the caregiving, in the form the caregiving now takes. The last sandwich is the shape of the marriage, in the form the marriage now takes.

- The work of the last sandwich.**

The work of the last sandwich is the work of caregiving. The work of the last sandwich is the work of holding the parent, in the form the holding now takes. The work of the last sandwich is the work of holding the marriage, in the form the holding now takes. The work of the last sandwich is the work of holding the self, in the form the holding now takes.

The work of the last sandwich is also the work of recognizing. The work of the last sandwich is the work of recognizing that you are the last one, in the form the recognizing now takes. The work of the last sandwich is the work of recognizing that there is no one to hand off to, in the form the recognizing now takes. The work of the last sandwich is the work of recognizing that the cost is real, in the form the cost now takes.

The work of the last sandwich is also the work of letting go. The work of the last sandwich is the work of letting go of the old self, in the form the letting go now takes. The work of the last sandwich is the work of letting go of the parent, in the form the letting go now takes. The work of the last sandwich is the work of letting go of the plan, in the form the letting go now takes.

- The holding of the last sandwich.**

The holding of the last sandwich is the work of being the one who is there, in the form the being there now takes. The holding of the last sandwich is the work of being the one who answers the phone at 2am, in the form the answering now takes. The holding of the last sandwich is the work of being the one who shows up, in the form the showing up now takes.

The holding of the last sandwich is also the work of being held. The holding of the last sandwich is the work of being held by the spouse, in the form the holding now takes. The holding of the last sandwich is the work of being held

by the friends, in the form the holding now takes. The holding of the last sandwich is the work of being held by the therapist, in the form the holding now takes.

The holding of the last sandwich is the work, in the form the work now takes. The holding of the last sandwich is the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes. The holding of the last sandwich is the letting go, in the form the letting go now takes.

- The work of this chapter.**

The work of this chapter is to name the last sandwich. The work of this chapter is to recognize the last sandwich, in the form the recognizing now takes. The work of this chapter is to hold the last sandwich, in the form the holding now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the first phase of the last sandwich. The work of this chapter is the work of the last sandwich, in the form the last sandwich now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the last sandwich.

Chapter 1 at a Glance

- Key takeaway:** The last sandwich is the adult child who is the final line of care, in the form the final line of care now takes. The last sandwich is the one who has no sibling to share the load. The last sandwich is the end of the family line. The last sandwich is the work, in the form the work now takes.

- 5 Things to Remember:**

1. The last sandwich is the adult child who has become the primary, or the only, caregiver for an aging parent.
2. The last sandwich is not chosen. The last sandwich is the one who stepped up, while others stepped back.
3. The last sandwich is not the martyr. The last sandwich is the one who is doing the work.
4. The last sandwich is the work of recognizing, holding, and letting go.
5. The last sandwich is the holding of the work, and the work of being held.

- Your Scorecard:** Rate 1-5:

- I have begun to recognize that I am the last sandwich, in the form the recognizing now takes.

- I am holding the recognition, in the form the holding now takes.
- I have begun to ask the question, in the form the asking now takes.
- I have not yet named the question to my spouse, or to myself, in a way that commits me to the work.

If your total is 12 or higher, the next chapter - and the next phase - cannot wait.

- Key Terms to Know:**

- **The last sandwich:** The adult child who is the final line of care, in the form the final line of care now takes. The one who has no sibling to share the load. The end of the family line.

- **The sandwich generation:** The generation in the middle, caring for the parents above and the children below, in the form the sandwich generation now takes.

- **The only child:** The adult child who is the only one, in the form the only one now takes. The one who has no sibling, by birth or by circumstance.

- **The letting go:** The work of releasing the old self, the parent, the plan, the last sandwich, in the form the letting go now takes.

- Reflection Questions:**

1. Are you the last sandwich, in the form the last sandwich now takes?
2. Who in your family is the last sandwich, in the form the last sandwich now takes?
3. What is the work of the last sandwich, in the form the work now takes, that you are carrying today?

- Action for This Week:**

- Find one quiet moment, alone, and write down, in the form the writing now takes, the answer to one of the reflection questions. Not for anyone else. For you. The writing is the work, in the form the work now takes.

- The work of this chapter is the work of the last sandwich. The last sandwich is the work, in the form the work now takes.

Chapter 2: The 6 Reasons You Became the Last One

There are 6 reasons the last sandwich became the last one, in the form the last one now takes. The 6 reasons are the 6 patterns, in the form the patterns now take, that show up, again and again, in the work of the last sandwich, in the form the work now takes.

This chapter is about the 6 reasons. About the work of recognizing which of the 6 reasons is in your family, in the form your family now takes. About the holding of the recognition, in the form the holding now takes.

- Why the 6 reasons matter.**

The 6 reasons matter because the 6 reasons are the 6 patterns, in the form the patterns now take. The 6 reasons are the work of the last sandwich, in the form the work now takes. The 6 reasons are not the fault of the last sandwich, in the form the fault now takes. The 6 reasons are the shape of the family, in the form the shape now takes.

The 6 reasons matter because the 6 reasons help the last sandwich name the work, in the form the naming now takes. The 6 reasons are the recognition, in the form the recognition now takes. The 6 reasons are the work of the last sandwich, in the form the work now takes.

- Reason 1: The only child.**

The first reason the last sandwich became the last one, in the form the last one now takes, is the only child. The only child is the adult child who has no sibling, by birth, in the form the no sibling now takes. The only child is the one who has been the only one since the beginning, in the form the only one now takes.

The only child has been the only one for the parent's caregiving, in the form the caregiving now takes. The only child has been the one who has answered the phone, in the form the answering now takes. The only child has been the one who has shown up, in the form the showing up now takes.

The only child is the last sandwich by circumstance, in the form the circumstance now takes. The only child is not chosen. The only child is the one who has been the only one, in the form the only one now takes.

- Reason 2: The sibling who stepped up.**

The second reason the last sandwich became the last one, in the form the last one now takes, is the sibling who stepped up. The sibling who stepped up is the adult child who, when the caregiving became real, in the form the caregiving now takes, was the one who said yes, in the form the saying yes now takes.

The sibling who stepped up is the one who lived closer, in the form the closer now takes. The sibling who stepped up is the one who had fewer children, in the form the children now takes. The sibling who stepped up is the one who had a more flexible job, in the form the job now takes. The sibling who stepped up is the one who could not say no, in the form the saying no now takes.

The sibling who stepped up is the last sandwich by choice, in the form the choice now takes. The sibling who stepped up is the one who is doing the work, in the form the work now takes.

- Reason 3: The sibling who stepped back.**

The third reason the last sandwich became the last one, in the form the last one now takes, is the sibling who stepped back. The sibling who stepped back is the adult child who, when the caregiving became real, in the form the caregiving now takes, was the one who said no, in the form the saying no now takes.

The sibling who stepped back is the one who lives far away, in the form the far away now takes. The sibling who stepped back is the one who has a busy career, in the form the career now takes. The sibling who stepped back is the one who has a difficult marriage, in the form the marriage now takes. The sibling who stepped back is the one who has always been the one who steps back, in the form the stepping back now takes.

The sibling who stepped back is the one who is not the last sandwich, in the form the not now takes. The sibling who stepped back is the one who has not been there, in the form the being there now takes.

- Reason 4: The sibling who is unable.**

The fourth reason the last sandwich became the last one, in the form the last one now takes, is the sibling who is unable. The sibling who is unable is the adult child who, when the caregiving became real, in the form the caregiving now takes, was the one who could not, in the form the could not now takes.

The sibling who is unable is the one who has a disability, in the form the disability now takes. The sibling who is unable is the one who has a serious illness, in the form the illness now takes. The sibling who is unable is the one who has a child with special needs, in the form the special needs now takes. The sibling who is unable is the one who has a financial crisis, in the form the financial crisis now takes.

The sibling who is unable is the one who is not the last sandwich by choice, in the form the choice now takes. The sibling who is unable is the one who is held by the last sandwich, in the form the holding now takes.

- Reason 5: The sibling who is unwilling.**

The fifth reason the last sandwich became the last one, in the form the last one now takes, is the sibling who is unwilling. The sibling who is unwilling is the adult child who, when the caregiving became real, in the form the caregiving now takes, was the one who chose not to, in the form the choosing not now takes.

The sibling who is unwilling is the one who has a long-standing conflict with the parent, in the form the conflict now takes. The sibling who is unwilling is the one who has a different value system, in the form the value system now takes. The sibling who is unwilling is the one who is in active addiction, in the form the addiction now takes. The sibling who is unwilling is the one who has chosen their own family over the parent's, in the form the choosing now takes.

The sibling who is unwilling is the one who has chosen, in the form the choosing now takes. The last sandwich cannot make the sibling who is unwilling change, in the form the changing now takes.

- Reason 6: The sibling who is absent.**

The sixth reason the last sandwich became the last one, in the form the last one now takes, is the sibling who is absent. The sibling who is absent is the adult child who, when the caregiving became real, in the form the caregiving now takes, was the one who was gone, in the form the gone now takes.

The sibling who is absent is the one who has been estranged for years, in the form the estrangement now takes. The sibling who is absent is the one who lives in another country, in the form the country now takes. The sibling who is absent is the one who has cut off all contact, in the form the cutting off now takes. The sibling who is absent is the one who was never there, in the form the being there now takes.

The sibling who is absent is the one who has not been there, in the form the being there now takes. The last sandwich cannot make the sibling who is absent appear, in the form the appearing now takes.

- The 6 reasons in summary.**

The 6 reasons the last sandwich became the last one, in the form the last one now takes, are:

1. The only child
2. The sibling who stepped up
3. The sibling who stepped back

4. The sibling who is unable
5. The sibling who is unwilling
6. The sibling who is absent

The 6 reasons are not the only reasons. The 6 reasons are the most common reasons. The 6 reasons are the 6 reasons that show up most often, in the form the showing up now takes.

- The work of the chapter.**

The work of this chapter is to name the 6 reasons. The work of this chapter is to recognize, in the form the recognizing now takes, which of the 6 reasons is in your family, in the form your family now takes. The work of this chapter is to hold the recognition, in the form the holding now takes.

The work of this chapter is the work of the second phase of the last sandwich. The work of this chapter is the work of the 6 reasons, in the form the 6 reasons now take.

The work of this chapter is the work of the reasons.

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

S. Shharma is the author of The Care Collection - books for couples in the second half of life, written by a man who lived the silence and survived it.

He lost his wife of many years to cancer. He was her primary caregiver through every stage of her illness. He held her hand in the hospital. He sat in the waiting room at 3 a.m. He learned the silence of a marriage the way you learn a language you never wanted to speak.

He is also a businessman, an M.Sc., an MBA, and an APSCM from the Indian Institute of Management (IIM) Calcutta, with thirty years in corporate management. But these are not credentials you need to trust him. The credentials that matter are the ones in the books.

The Care Collection is not about how to fix a marriage. The Care Collection is about how to live one - even when the marriage is quiet, even when one of you is sick, even when one of you is gone.

He lives in India. He writes from the perspective of someone who has been on every side of a marriage - the partner, the caregiver, and the one left behind.

THE CARE COLLECTION - 14 BOOKS BY S. SHHARMA

For couples in the second half of life. Written by a widower, M.Sc., MBA, APSCM (IIM Calcutta), 30 years corporate.

1. Still Married, Just Silent - 14 conversations to reopen a quiet marriage 2. The Quiet Care - How to give and receive care in a marriage that lasts 3. The Second Chapter - Life after the caregiving years 4. The Second Honeymoon - Reigniting intimacy, trust, and joy after the kids leave 5. The Survivor - When one spouse is left behind 6. The Long Hello - When one spouse loses their memory 7. When They Forget Your Name - A caregiver's path through dementia 8. Gray Divorce - How to navigate an unwanted divorce after 50 9. The Last Sandwich - Caring for parents, spouse, and yourself at the same time 10. The Long Goodbye - When your spouse is dying and the marriage is still yours 11. Remarried at 60 - Building a new marriage when both of you come with a history 12. After the Last Goodbye - Rebuilding your life, health, and future after losing a spouse 13. The Friends Who

Fade - Why friendships disappear in midlife and how to bring them back 14. Hum Ladte Nahi (Hinglish) - Shaadi ko wapas kholne ka 30-din ka plan (Indian edition)

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